

A Changing tastes



Throughout the centuries, people have tended to be suspicious of the new art movements of their period. At the end of the 19th century, for example, people were shocked by **Impressionism**¹, criticising its practitioners as careless **daubers**². Later, when faced with **Cubist**³ paintings, the public were puzzled by those too. The **Surrealists**⁴ were initially **deemed**⁵ crazy. **Op-art**⁶ was criticised because its **subject matter**⁷ was said to consist of nothing of significance. However, nowadays, liking **Surrealism**⁸ or Op-art is considered perfectly acceptable, and images from these **schools of art**⁹ appear everywhere, from posters to advertising campaigns. Perhaps because of the ubiquity of advertising, people tend to be more **visually literate**¹⁰ than they used to be, and so are perhaps **inured to**¹¹ surprises. Perhaps new movements in art will meet with less hostility in future.

1, 3, 4, 6, 8 types of artist and schools of art of the last 150 years 2 someone who paints quickly and carelessly (disapproving) 5 considered; *formal* 7 content 9 art movement 10 educated with regard to art 11 not affected by

B Words for commenting on art

original: new in a special and interesting way (*opp.* = **predictable**)

highbrow: intended for educated, intelligent people (often disapproving) (*opp.* = **lowbrow**)

impenetrable: extremely difficult to understand (*opp.* = **transparent**)

sophisticated: showing advanced skills and understanding (*opp.* = **primitive**)

challenging: demanding considerable effort to be understood (*opp.* = **undemanding**)

dazzling: inspiring great admiration because it is brilliant in some way (*opp.* = **pedestrian**)

evocative: calling up images and memories (*opp.* = **uninspiring**)

thought-provoking: making people think (*opp.* = **unstimulating**)

exquisite: having rare beauty or delicacy (*opp.* = **clumsy**)

intriguing: interesting because it is strange or mysterious (*opp.* = **dreary**)

peerless: better than any other (*opp.* = **run-of-the-mill**)

tongue-in-cheek: not intended to be taken seriously, despite appearing serious (*opp.* = **earnest**)

priceless: extremely valuable (*opp.* = **worthless**)

skilful: clever, masterly, done well (*opp.* = **poorly done**)

C Art and metaphor

Notice how words connected with art can be used when talking about literature.

The writer **paints** his hero in a fascinating **light**. Minor characters are more **shadowy** or **sketchy** but they are also **depicted** quite powerfully, even though the focus is, inevitably, on the two central characters. These are **portrayed** with great sensitivity. The heroine is particularly **colourful** and we see how her character is **shaped** and **moulded** by events. Some say the author **illustrates** his **motifs** in a black-and-white fashion, but the **image** he creates to **illuminate** the evils of slavery will remain with me for ever.